Melbourne → Adelaide by the Great Ocean Road · 23–28 Dec 2026

2026-12-23 → 2026-12-28 · 6 days · 3 travellers · Total 1128 km · longest day 3 h 48

Everything checked fits. 8 details still need confirming (see Open items).

Date	Route	km	Driving	Sunset	Overnight
Day 1 · Wed 23 Dec	Land, pick up car, Geelong	78	1 h 07	20:45	Holiday Inn & Suites Geelong (IHG)
Day 2 · Thu 24 Dec	Great Ocean Road: Torquay to Port Campbell	213	3 h 48	20:53	Port Campbell, to choose
Day 3 · Fri 25 Dec	Christmas Day: Twelve Apostles and Tower Hill	200	3 h 13	20:58	Portland, to choose (with kitchen)
Day 4 · Sat 26 Dec	Boxing Day: into South Australia	290	3 h 46	20:31	Kingston SE, to choose
Day 5 · Sun 27 Dec	Coorong to Adelaide	295	3 h 41	20:30	Crowne Plaza Adelaide (IHG)
Day 6 · Mon 28 Dec	Cleland koalas, Glenelg, fly home	51	1 h 10	20:31	—

Day by day

Day 1 · Wed 23 Dec · Land, pick up car, Geelong

depart 09:45 · 78 km · Driving 1 h 07 · Sunset 20:45 · Overnight Holiday Inn & Suites Geelong (IHG)

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
09:45 depart	Melbourne Airport		Land 08:30. Collect bags and the one-way car with the child seat fitted.
10:58	Geelong waterfront	78 km 1 h 07	Hotel. Afternoon on the waterfront and Eastern Beach. Easy first day.

Day 2 · Thu 24 Dec · Great Ocean Road: Torquay to Port Campbell

depart 09:00 · 213 km · Driving 3 h 48 · Sunset 20:53 · Overnight Port Campbell, to choose

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
09:00 depart	Geelong waterfront		
09:39–09:54	Bells Beach lookout	31 km 36 min	Surf lookout. Skip if running late.
10:19–10:49	Split Point Lighthouse, Aireys Inlet	20 km 23 min	Lighthouse from outside.
11:03–11:13	Great Ocean Road Memorial Arch, Eastern View	7 km 12 min	Photo stop.
11:35–12:50	Lorne	14 km 20 min	Lunch and the beach.
13:16–14:01	Kennett River koala spotting	22 km 24 min	Wild koalas. Park on the main road and WALK up Grey River Rd (gravel: don't drive it).
14:26–14:56	Apollo Bay	23 km 23 min	Fuel, and food for Christmas Day: most shops shut 25 Dec.
15:15–15:55	Maits Rest rainforest walk	17 km 17 min	800 m rainforest boardwalk, ~30 min.
17:15	Port Campbell	80 km 1 h 13	Overnight.

Day 3 · Fri 25 Dec · Christmas Day: Twelve Apostles and Tower Hill

depart 08:45 · 200 km · Driving 3 h 13 · Sunset 20:58 · Overnight Portland, to choose (with kitchen)

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
08:45 depart	Port Campbell		
08:57–09:17	Gibson Steps	12 km 11 min	Steps to the beach under the cliffs.
09:18–10:18	Twelve Apostles Visitor Centre	1 km 1 min	Booked free 09:00 or 09:30 slot (it also holds your parking).
10:22–11:07	Loch Ard Gorge	4 km 4 min	Gorge and beach. No booking.
11:23–11:38	London Bridge (London Arch)	15 km 14 min	Arch lookout.
12:08–12:23	Bay of Islands lookout	28 km 28 min	Lookout.
13:23–14:53	Tower Hill Wildlife Reserve	50 km 54 min	Emus, koalas, kangaroos in a crater. Centre shut today, reserve open. BBQ picnic lunch.
15:17–16:02	Port Fairy	17 km 22 min	Stroll by the harbour.
17:07	Portland	72 km 59 min	Overnight. Self-cater Christmas dinner, or book a restaurant now.

Day 4 · Sat 26 Dec · Boxing Day: into South Australia

depart 09:00 · 290 km · Driving 3 h 46 · Sunset 20:31 · Overnight Kingston SE, to choose

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
09:00 depart	Portland		
10:00–10:30	Blue Lake, Mount Gambier	105 km 1 h 22	Bright blue crater lake. SA clocks are 30 min behind.
10:40–11:20	Umpherston Sinkhole, Mount Gambier	6 km 9 min	Sinkhole garden, free. Fuel here.
13:10–14:25	Robe	136 km 1 h 40	Lunch and the beach.
15:03	Kingston SE (Big Lobster)	44 km 35 min	Overnight. See the Big Lobster.

Day 5 · Sun 27 Dec · Coorong to Adelaide

depart 09:00 · 295 km · Driving 3 h 41 · Sunset 20:30 · Overnight Crowne Plaza Adelaide (IHG)

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
09:00 depart	Kingston SE (Big Lobster)		
10:59–11:44	Meningie	146 km 1 h 49	Break by Lake Albert, fuel. Coorong lagoons beside the road.
13:48	Adelaide city centre	149 km 1 h 52	Hotel. Free afternoon.

Day 6 · Mon 28 Dec · Cleland koalas, Glenelg, fly home

depart 09:05 · 51 km · Driving 1 h 10 · Sunset 20:31

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
09:05 depart	Adelaide city centre		Check out.
09:32–12:02	Cleland Wildlife Park	18 km 25 min	Koalas, kangaroos and other native animals. Opens 09:30.
12:42–15:02	Glenelg beach (Moseley Square)	27 km 36 min	Beach, playground, lunch. Leave by 15:00.
15:12	Adelaide Airport (car return)	6 km 9 min	Refuel, return car by 16:00. Flight 18:00.

Bookings and tickets

Book by	Item	Date	Status	Ref	Terms / notes
2026-11-16	One-way car MEL→ADL, child seat, both adults as drivers	2026-12-23	not booked		check one-way fee · rental company site
2026-11-30	Twelve Apostles free timed entry, 09:00	2026-12-25	not booked		no walk-ups · twelveapostles.org.au
2026-12-14	Cleland entry (koala hold extra, pre-book)	2026-12-28	not booked		clelandwildlifepark.sa.gov.au

Hotels

Date	Hotel	Brand	Room	Cost	Status	Terms / notes
2026-12-23	Holiday Inn & Suites Geelong (IHG)	IHG			not booked	free cancellation, ≤A$350, 2 queens/family room · ihg.com
2026-12-24	Port Campbell, to choose	—			not booked	free cancellation, ≤A$350, 2 queens/family room · visit12apostles.com.au
2026-12-25	Portland, to choose (with kitchen)	—			not booked	free cancellation, ≤A$350, 2 queens/family room · visitgreatoceanroad.org.au
2026-12-26	Kingston SE, to choose	—			not booked	free cancellation, ≤A$350, 2 queens/family room · southaustralia.com
2026-12-27	Crowne Plaza Adelaide (IHG)	IHG			not booked	free cancellation, ≤A$350, 2 queens/family room · ihg.com

Open items

Your requirements

- [met] At most 350 km in any day
- [met] No more than about 4 hours of driving a day
- [met] Off the road at least 1 hour before sunset, no driving before sunrise (kangaroos)
- [met] No helicopter or scenic flights
- [met] No walks over about 1 hour
- [met] No unsealed (gravel) roads: the rental contract forbids them
- [met] Car returned at Adelaide Airport by 16:00 on 28 Dec; sightseeing only until 15:00
- [to confirm] Child seat for a 6-year-old in the car
- [to confirm] Hotel up to A$350 per night
- [to confirm] One room for three: family room or two queen beds

Backup plans

- Great Ocean Road closed or delayed (landslip, works, fire) on 24 Dec (decide by 2026-12-23): VicTraffic and VicEmergency on the evening of 23 Dec · Plan B: Geelong → Colac → Cobden → Port Campbell inland, 166 km, about 2 h 25 (checked); you miss Lorne to Apollo Bay · https://traffic.vicroads.vic.gov.au/
- Catastrophic fire danger day: parks and Cleland close (decide by the evening before each day): Fire danger rating the evening before (CFA in Victoria, CFS in SA) · Stay on highways and in towns; if Cleland is shut on 28 Dec, spend the morning at Glenelg · https://clelandwildlifepark.sa.gov.au/plan-your-visit/opening-hours
- IHG: only Geelong and Adelaide have IHG hotels near the route, so 3 nights are non-brand.
- Hotel prices not checked yet: filter ≤A$350, 1 room for 3, free cancellation.
- Twelve Apostles on 25 Dec: site says open daily; confirm when booking.
- Great Ocean Road works and landslips: check VicTraffic on 23 Dec.
- Hotel desk hours: all arrivals are by 17:15; check anyway.
- Christmas dinner: few places open; self-cater or book in Portland now.

Before you go

Checklist

• Rental: both adults on the contract; child seat booked; one-way fee and fuel policy checked; unsealed roads are excluded.

• Book the free Twelve Apostles slot (no walk-ups).

• Buy Christmas food on 24 Dec in Lorne or Apollo Bay; fill the tank on 24 Dec too.

• Check VicTraffic and the fire danger rating each evening.

• SA clocks are 30 min behind Victoria from 26 Dec.

• Download offline maps in case phone signal drops on the coast.

Packing

• Sun hats, sunscreen, water bottles

• Warm layer: coast wind is cold even in summer

• Shoes with grip for steps and boardwalks

• Picnic gear and a cooler bag for Christmas Day

• Car charger and phone mount

• Motion-sickness tablets: the road is very winding

Sources

• https://www.greatoceanroadauthority.vic.gov.au/Projects/Twelve-Apostles-Visitor-Centre (2026-11-09)

• https://www.standard.net.au/story/9364010/twelve-apostles-launches-new-booking-system-for-visitors/ (2026-11-09)

• https://www.twelveapostles.org.au/ (2026-11-09)

• https://lightstation.com/operating-hours (2026-11-09)

• https://secretmelbourne.com/kennett-river-koala-walk/ (2026-11-09)

• https://www.greatoceanroadauthority.vic.gov.au/Land-We-Manage/National-Parks/Great-Otway-National-Park/Maits-Rest-Rainforest-Walk (2026-11-09)

• https://www.parks.vic.gov.au/places-to-see/parks/Tower-Hill-Wildlife-Reserve (2026-11-09)

• https://business.vic.gov.au/business-information/public-holidays/operating-on-a-public-holiday (2026-11-09)

• https://www.safework.sa.gov.au/resources/public-holidays (2026-11-09)

• https://clelandwildlifepark.sa.gov.au/plan-your-visit/opening-hours (2026-11-09)

• https://www.sa.gov.au/topics/driving-and-transport/roads-and-traffic/seatbelts-and-child-restraints (2026-11-09)

• https://www.ihgplc.com/en/news-and-media/news-releases/2023/holiday-inn-and-suites-geelong-opens-in-the-heart-of-victorias-thriving-regional-centre (2026-11-09)

• https://www.surfcoast.vic.gov.au/About-us/Road-upgrades-and-works/Anglesea-and-Aireys-Inlet-area-projects/Fairhaven-landslip (2026-11-09)

• https://playandgo.com.au/umpherston-sinkhole-mount-gambier/ (2026-11-09)